



Implicit Race Bias in Mock-Juror Convictions



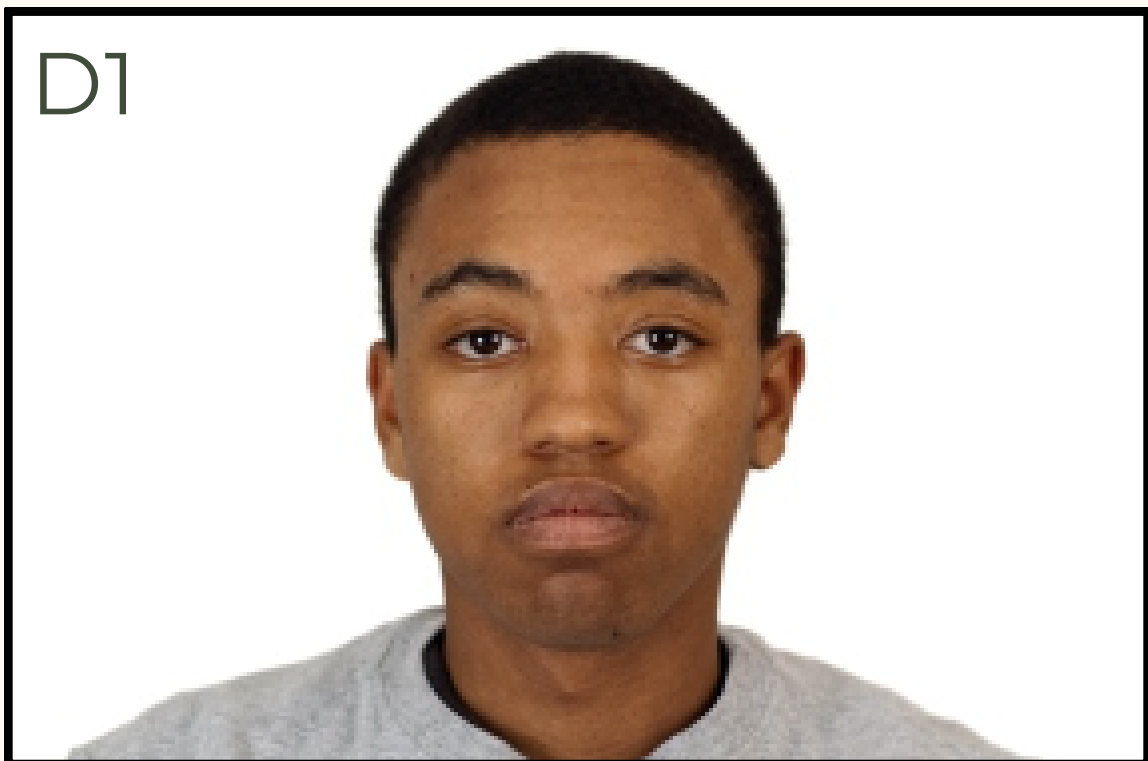
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Introduction

Prior research has shown that racial bias plays a significant role in the likelihood of conviction of defendants^{1,2}. The critical question is, what non-factual factors affect jurors' decision-making, particularly in response to racially diverse defendants?

This study, conducted within a larger study on mock-juror bias, examined whether white mock-jurors were more or less likely to convict a black defendant after first adjudicating a white vs. black defendant in a prior case, and vice versa for non-white jurors, as a means of fulfilling social desirability bias.

Additionally, we also assessed whether mock-jurors accurately estimated defendant age based on racial biases as an added predictor for a factorial analysis of variance in assigned criminal culpability scores, as studied in previous research³.



Methodology

132 participants were recruited via Prolific; (White: 96, NonWhite: 36). They completed all three studies on Qualtrics and were randomly assigned to 1 of 3 conditions in the Race section:

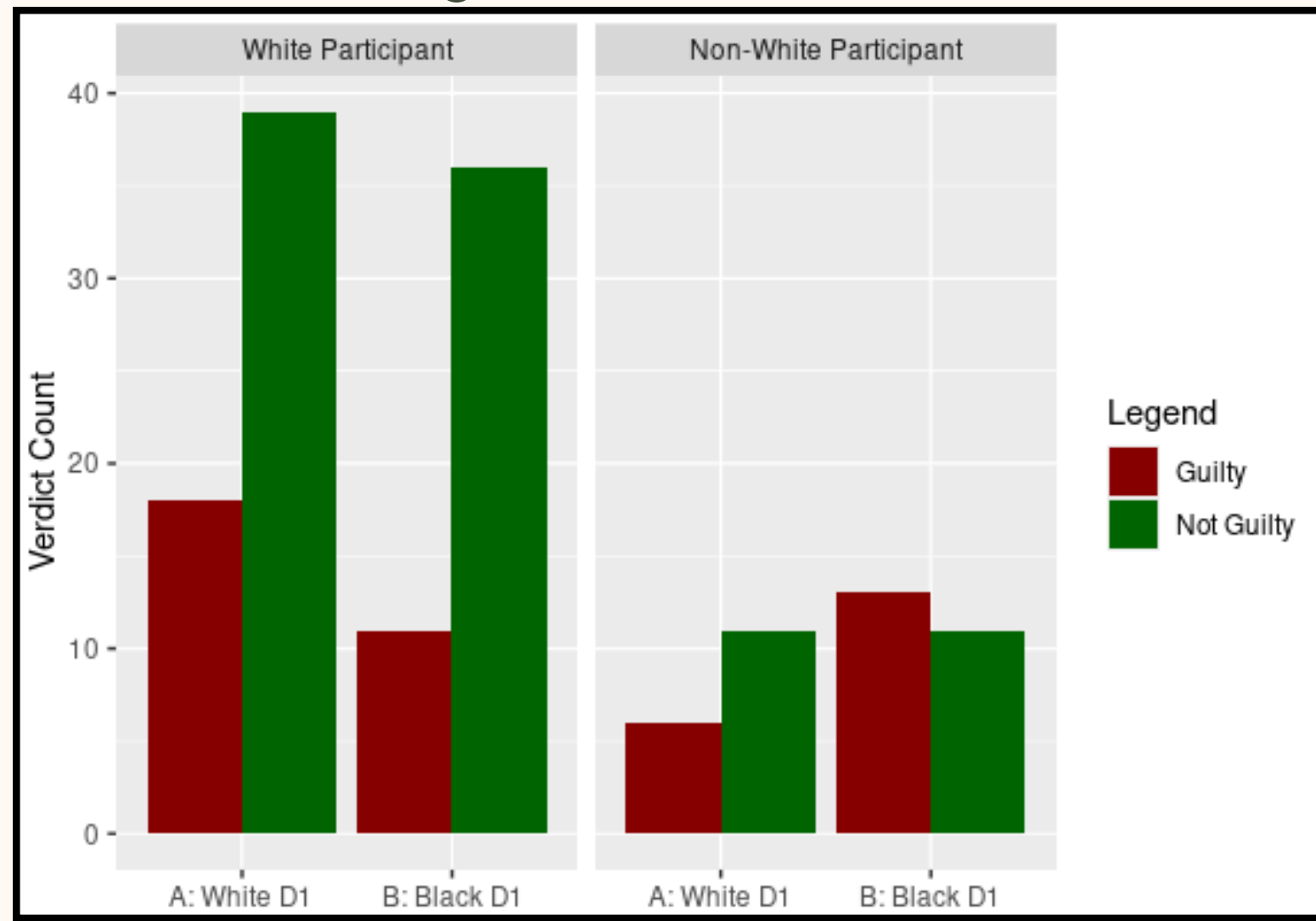
- Group A: participants read two criminal reports, where the 1st defendant was White, 2nd Black.
- Group B: same as A, both defendants were Black.
- Group C: only one case report - Black defendant.

Criminal reports had three components –

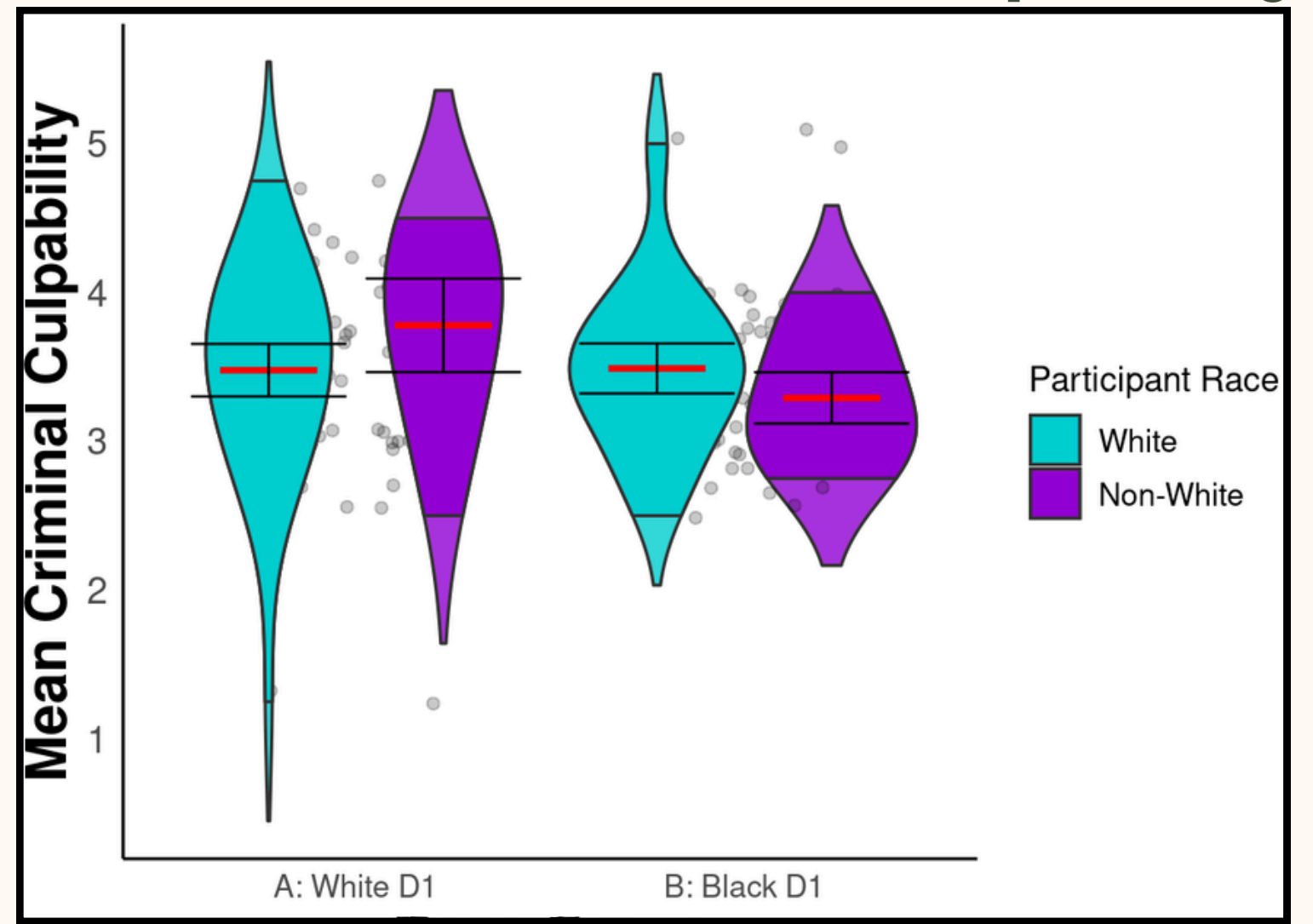
- Criminal records sheet describing 1-2 prior charges per defendant
- Picture of defendant
- State and Defense Court Arguments.

Participants then answered questions regarding guilt, responsibility and age of defendant before completing the rest of the study (effects of language and emotional priming).

Def 1: Guilty Verdicts

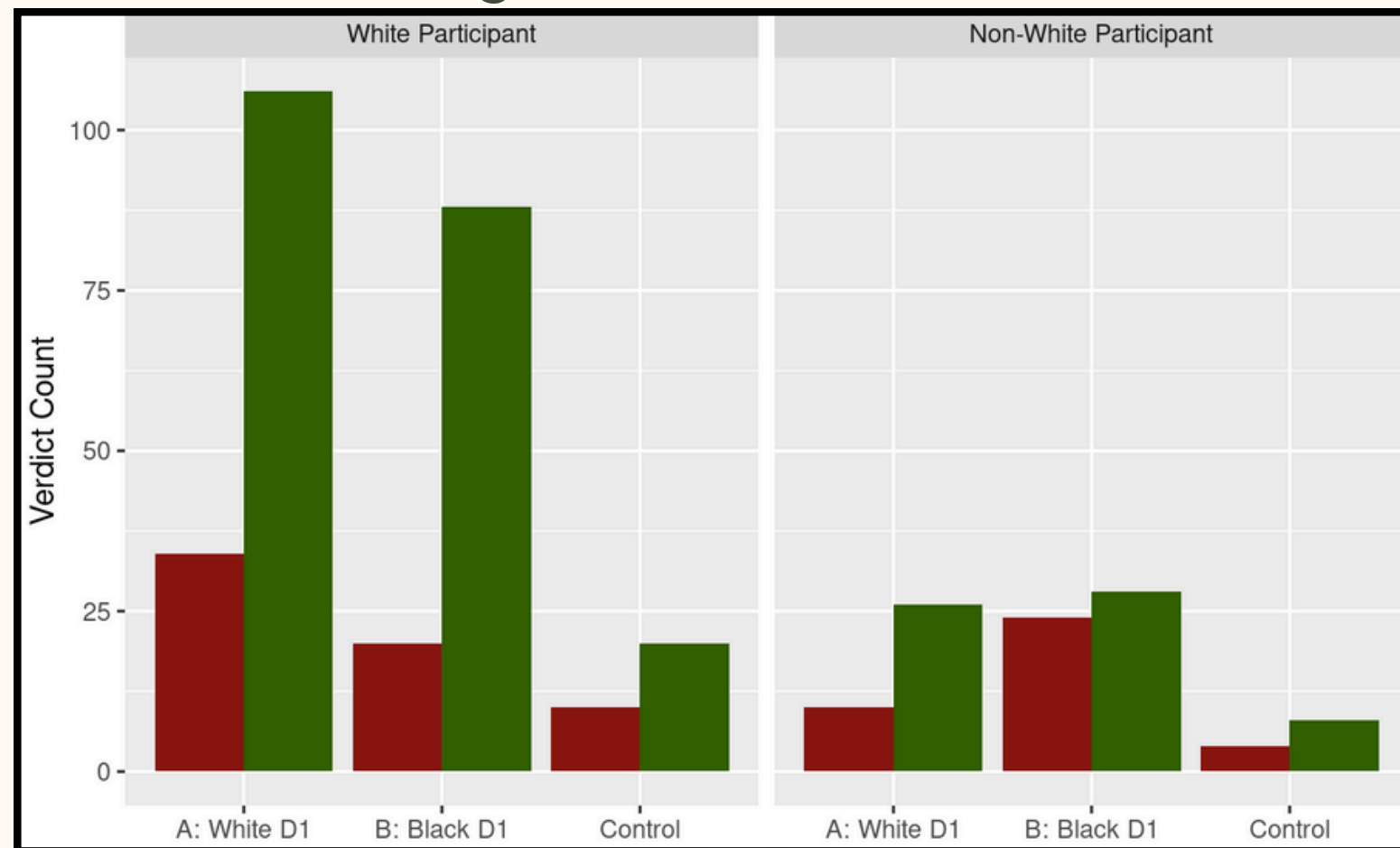


Def 1: Mean Criminal Culpability

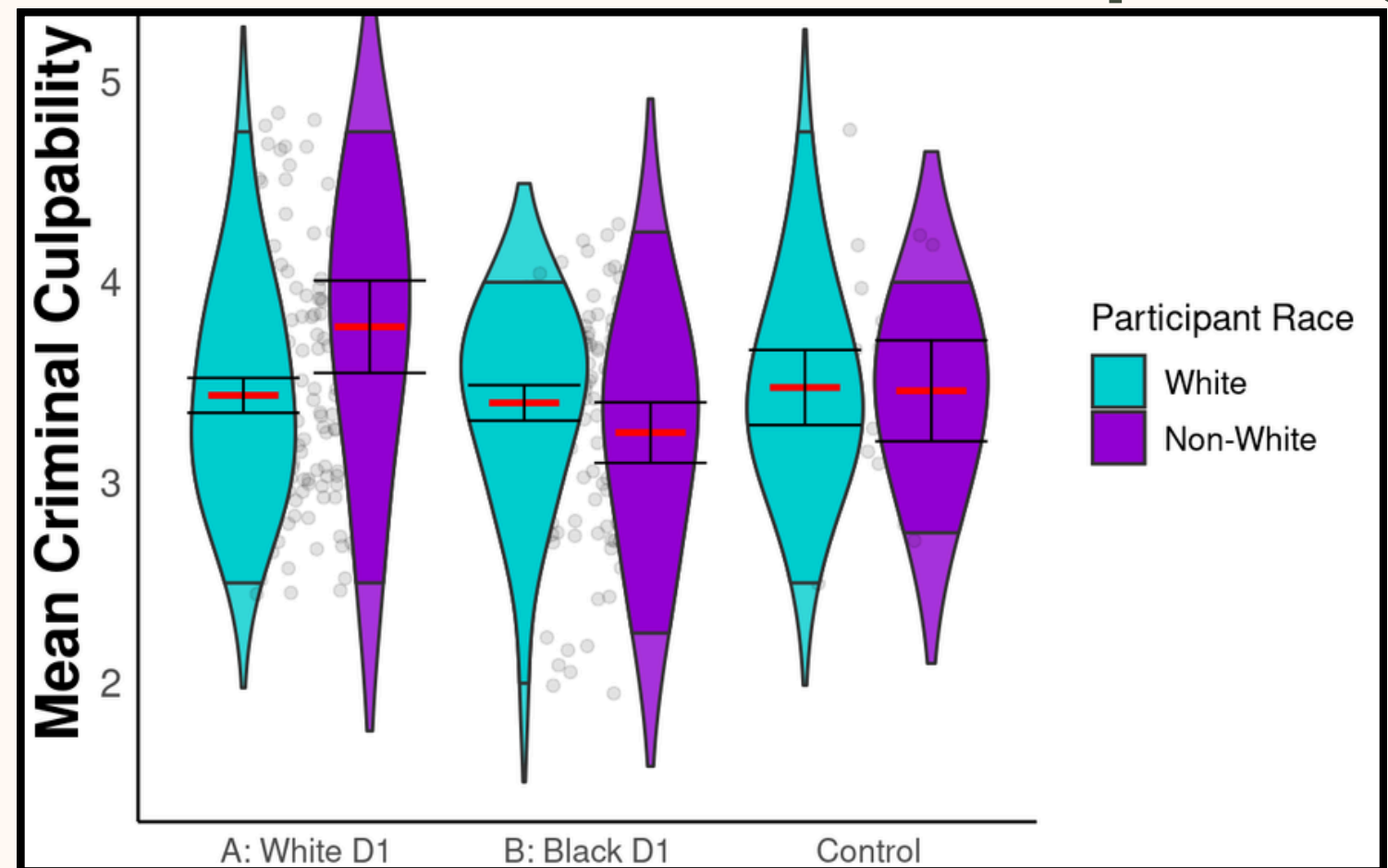


While no effects reached statistical significance ($p < 0.05$), two interactions (PartRace $\times$ DefRace, and DefRace $\times$ AgeAccuracy) trended toward significance, hinting at subtle race and adultification bias in assigning criminal culpability to Defendant 1.

Def 2: Guilty Verdicts



Def 2: Mean Criminal Culpability



There was a near-significant main effect of RaceGroup ($p = .052$) and interaction with PartRace ($p = .105$) for Defendant 2, suggesting racial context and participant identity may influence culpability judgments, trends suggesting social desirability bias. A larger and more diverse sample size would yield more significant conclusions.